



The Galápagos Islands

A group of Pacific islands, whose unique ecosystem and wildlife provide extraordinary insights into evolution

Clustered around the equator about 620 miles (1,000km) off the coast of Ecuador, the rocky Galápagos Islands consist of 13 major islands, six smaller ones, and more than 100 small outcrops. All are situated on the Nazca tectonic plate, whose slow but steady movement eastward results in frequent volcanic eruptions. Three major ocean currents converge here, bringing in a variety of marine creatures as well as creating a much cooler climate than expected at the equator.

A window on evolution

Due to the islands' remote location and volcanic conditions, life in the Galápagos evolved in relative isolation, and many species, such as native iguanas and giant tortoises, have not changed radically since

prehistoric times. The adaptations of animals on different islands that led to their divergence as separate species inspired the British naturalist Charles Darwin to develop his groundbreaking theory of evolution in the 19th century. Today, the Galápagos is one of the world's most scientifically and biologically important regions, where unique native species make up a very high proportion of the islands' wildlife.

▷ DAISY TREE

The shrubby Stewart's scalesia grows only on Santiago and Bartolomé Islands. Its daisy-shaped flower heads release dandelion-like seeds.

